

Into the Rabbit Hole

Their paths had been forged long before this moment, though neither had fully grasped it until now.

With their resolve set in stone, the tannery became the threshold between past and future. Here, Ferris would lay down his tools—not to forget, but to move forward. The quiet craft that had once tethered him to grief would now be left behind, making way for something greater. Yae, too, would set aside her duty as the Keeper of the Tree, stepping into a journey not of obligation, but of self-discovery.

This is the story of that final meeting—the last time they stood as who they had been, before stepping forward as who they would become.

Yae

It was time, he said. Time to go and fight for what's right.

The day had begun like any other. I rose from my bed in the quiet grove, the smell of pine still clinging to my hair. I offered my morning prayers to the Feydorian gods—not just to my father, Danche, the Huntfather, but to them all.

Ansellich

, god of protection.

Tantau

, god of harvest. Each name passed through my lips like leaves in the wind.

The other druids at the Grandfather Tree often scoffed at me for it.

"Druids don't pray," they whispered.

Let them whisper. I had found my truth in the silence after prayer.

I held my most recent harvest of feybloom in my hands, letting its scent rise and fill my lungs. Then it came—

a chill

, sudden and strange, curling around my spine like frost through roots.

And there, before me, stood a deer. But not any deer. Majestic. Otherworldly. His antlers were adorned with

red feybloom

, the kind that only grows in Feydor—my homeland, my loss.

He gazed at me, steady and knowing.

“Yaereene. Come closer. It has been nineteen years.”

I tilted my head, unsure.

“Your mother... it is time to avenge her. Grief has befallen me, too.”

My heart seized. The truth struck like a chord pulled too tight. I knew that voice. Knew it in my blood.

“Father?”

I whispered.

“Yes,” he said, and the world stilled.

“It is I—

Danche

, god of the hunt, leader of the gods... and more importantly now,

your father

, Yae.”

I couldn't breathe. His voice wasn't loud, but it carried more weight than thunder.

"It is time. Ferris needs healing. And you, daughter, need solace... and retribution."

His tone changed then. Firmer. Like bark cracking in frost.

"As the god of the hunt—which means making war as much as finding food—I would be remiss, my daughter, not to rebuke you for your waiting. What good has come from it? Look at Ferris. What has he gained?"

I clenched my jaw.

"I chose your mother not just because she was queen, but because of her
resolve

. Her

grace

. Her

humor

, even in the face of ruin. She worried nightly for her husband, but never wavered.
And those same seeds, daughter, bloom in you.

"Your compassion for the lost, the hunted, the grieving—those broken by the
forces we gods dare not speak of—

that

is your power. It is why I blessed this world with you."

I felt my druidic markings warm on my skin, glowing faintly in response to
something ancient, something real.

"Let your grief speak in your magic. Let it mark you. The druid's art is not stillness

—it is

transformation

. Now is the time to act. Not with guilt—but with

purpose

.”

The wind shifted, as if his presence moved through it.

“Go with Ferris. Raise him as you rise. And let them all learn what it means when the

daughter of Danche

walks the land again.”

And then, just like that, he was gone.

But I was not alone.

Not anymore.

After I finished my duties to the tree, I prayed one more time.

Father, oh high god, thank you for the rallying cry.

Even though this is not a tree of Feydor, please, for your daughter, protect this tree.

May nothing befall its branches, may war never grace its boughs.

To Danche, my father, may this tree ever be flowering.

As if in response, a single vine of feybloom—

Feydorian

, unmistakably—curled into bloom upon the trunk. Red as blood, soft as breath.

I smiled. A quiet, reverent thing.

Then I rose, turned my eyes toward the east, and walked to the tannery.

It is time

, I said to myself.

Ferris

The bells of my door rang, as I was hard at work.

Calon called out to me from the front, "Customer, sir Ferris!"

I set my tools down and stepped out.

It was her—

Yae

.

"If I may have a moment, Calon," I said, prompting the young boy—no more than a few years Yae's junior—to give us privacy.

"I take it that you're returning my letter?"

She nodded, somewhat stunned, her eyes catching sight of Calon over my shoulder.

In Druidic, she told me as much.

As I turned to glance back at Calon, she slipped something into my pocket.

A note, perhaps? But no—

I felt the unmistakable warmth of Feydorian feybloom

, braided into the cool, gentle touch of

High Forest's own

.

When I turned back to speak with her again, she was gone.

In my pocket was, indeed, a note—wreathed in

blue and red feybloom

, vibrant and fragrant with memory and purpose.

I read it, shielding my eyes from Calon. I had hidden tears before. I knew how.

It is time.

Three words in Druidic. And they cut deeper than most letters ever could.

Calon watched me quietly, then asked, with innocent curiosity,

"Who is that?"

"Just... a friend."

I knelt to meet his eyes.

"Listen, Calon, for I will only say this once. Water the plants once a day—especially the red one.

Take care not to damage it. Use it to create dye, particularly for those lost souls who ask for red.

The orders are on the counter, beneath my—
your
—workbench.

I've been called.

You've learned much already, I hope. If not, you'll learn more by doing. Seek someone with fashion sense when you're stuck.

And most importantly—take care of the chair.

I'll write as soon as I can. It may not be soon.

Farewell, Calon."

I touched the chair— the spirit of Brell— as I left, weapons in hand, never to return.

Her cabin was sparse—nothing unnecessary, nothing wasted. Perhaps it was the habit of someone who had been running from grief for too long. I understood that well enough.

"We leave at midnight," Yae said, settling into the single chair that stood in the small space. "I've already spoken to the guards."

I remained standing. "Okay... and provisions?"

"Handled."

She glanced at me then. "Do you have your implements? For battle?"

I pulled my bag from my back, unfastened the straps, and drew my bow—

Brellich

—named in honor of my brother. My longsword followed.

Yae nodded. "Good."

"And you?"

She turned toward the cabinet—empty of food, but not of steel. When she pulled her weapon free, I felt my breath catch for just a moment.

It was beautiful.

The hilt was a branch of pale wood, its shape woven through itself in twisting strands, as though grown rather than carved. Embedded at its base were two spheres filled with a shimmering red liquid—Feydorian feybloom, distilled into something potent. The blade itself bore the plant's vines, laced along the steel like living veins.

I told her as much.

"Thank you," she said softly. For the briefest moment, I thought I saw the color rise to her cheeks, but she didn't address it.

Instead, she asked, "Want some food?"

I nodded.

"Here. I was going to save this for my deer, but hopefully, I'll find more."

That caught my interest—not the food, but the idea of Yae having a deer as a familiar.

"When I heard my mother's story," she said, gesturing broadly toward the velvety antlers crowning her head, "these suddenly made a lot more sense."

"So I chose a deer—a doe, to be more specific. She wears my feybloom on her antlers."

I considered that for a moment before rolling up my sleeve. "You know what?"

"Hmm?"

"I have a mark like your antlers."

The blue lines of my
druidic mark

curled along my forearm, woven into my skin with High Forest feybloom dye. A
branch of the

Grandfather Tree

itself, etched in magic rather than ink. It brightened when I was in tune with

Brellich

, my bow, my brother's namesake. Now, unused, it was muted, blending into my
skin tone.

"Is that your druidic mark?" Yae asked.

"Yes. What is yours?"

She traced a finger across her face. "This."

The mark was sharp, striking, the same deep red as Feydorian feybloom. But its meaning ran deeper—it was not only a symbol of her homeland, but of the blood spilled upon it.

"And yours?" she asked.

I smiled. "Mine is a reminder to remember my roots. Brell died under the Grandfather Tree. It's only fitting that I honor it with my druidic mark."

I let the words settle before shifting the conversation back to something else. "But enough about our marks—what is in those spheres on your sword?"

She glanced at the weapon beside her and smiled.

"Feybloom poison, just in case."

The light was fading, the edges of the room darkening in the absence of the sun. Yae's shoulders were heavier now, exhaustion settling in.

"Shall we retire?" she asked. "I made up a bed in my loft, if you so desire."

She never stops impressing me. I accept.

Yae

The night had settled, cloaking the forest in quiet shadows when I awoke. I turned my gaze to Ferris, still fast asleep. I hadn't truly looked at him before—always too focused on my own story, my own wounds. But now, in the stillness of my loft, I saw the grief written across his face. It mirrored my own.

His hair fell in loose heaps, silver with a faint blue tinge—the mark, no doubt, of his connection to High Forest feybloom. Scars crossed his face in quiet testimony to battles fought and lost, and even in slumber, he looked rueful, as though his dreams carried sorrow. For a moment, I hesitated, then gently shook him awake.

He stirred groggily, sitting up and glancing around at the space I called my “nest.” It reminded me of the tree-shelters I'd made while fleeing Feydor—a place that felt both safe and temporary. The loft was sparse but decorated with purpose: blooms from Feydor and the High Forest nestled among the beams, a spell fountain casting diffused light from its soft embers—a restrained Create Bonfire for reading spells in the dark.

“Ach, is it time to go already?” he mumbled, still heavy with sleep.

“Yes,” I replied. “We should visit the tannery, your home, and the Tree before we leave. Say goodbye, for we may never return to find these places as they are.”

He nodded but gave a tired shake of his head. “Fair. But we can skip the tannery and my home. Let's just visit the Tree.”

That was understandable. I reached over, snuffing out the spell in the fountain, allowing darkness to settle over the room. Turning my attention to the corner, I picked up the least mature pot of feybloom I owned, cradled in a basket I had made myself. It wasn't perfect—my skills in woodworking would never match Brell's—but it was sturdy. I'd crafted it with care, drawing on the techniques taught by the High Forest fey and the few I had met in my youth.

The basket was woven with druidic intent, a snug home for the soil and feybloom it carried, nurtured by both my magic and the Tree's essence. It would do for now until we reached a place known for finer druidic craftsmanship.

“Nice basket,” Ferris said, his voice curious, tinged with admiration.

I smiled, explaining that I had made it myself. It wasn't intricate, but it served its purpose well: shielding Verdant Leaf, the young feybloom, from prying eyes and those who might seek to misuse it. Most days, the basket rested on my back, and when it didn't, I kept it close at hand.

He looked surprised, taking the basket and inspecting it. “I'm not too good at basket craft, but... it looks sturdy. How long have you had it?”

“Since leaving Feydor. A year and a half now,” I said, my fingers brushing the edge of the pot. “Are we going?”

Ferris nodded, though his excitement and dread both hung heavy in the air. I understood that weight; it was one I carried too. Even now, with the path ahead clear, the fear of stepping forward still lingered.

I took a final glance around the loft, blessing the door before I closed it. A note written in Druidic and Common hung upon it, instructions for caring for the remaining feybloom. I sighed—a long exhale of both relief and finality.

Then, with one last push of resolve, I closed the door on a chapter of my life. A chapter filled with grief, survival, and quiet joy.

It was time.

Ferris

The air was cold, much like my thoughts. I carried sadness, yes, but it wasn't the weight of despair—it was tethered to something greater. Purpose loomed in the distance, waiting to be met.

As Yae and I made our way through the village nestled beneath the Grandfather Tree, my steps were slow but steady. The lanterns swayed gently in the breeze, casting fragmented light onto the ground. Despite everything, I felt a small smile touch my lips. Yae meant more to me now than I ever expected. She wasn't just a party mate or a passing ally—she felt like a sister, someone whose grief and resolve mirrored my own.

She nodded at the guards as we neared the gate. "Hark," she said softly, her voice cutting through the stillness.

"Ferris? Keeper of the Tree?" the lead guard asked, his fey features sharp, his tone formal but not unkind.

"Yes," I replied, though it was Yae who stepped forward, reaching into the pocket of her basket. Her long, graceful arms moved with ease as she produced the note.

"Here's the elder's message," she said, handing it over.

The guard took the parchment, scanning it with a rueful smile that didn't quite reach his eyes. "I take it we'll see you later?"

"If the gods of Feydor and the fey allow. Although, sadly, most likely not." My voice wavered slightly as I spoke, and I could feel the bittersweetness threading through my words. I bowed deeply, nearly overcome, before asking, "May we have leave?"

He gave a resolute nod. "May the gods of the Feywild guide you, and your destiny. Farewell, for I may not see you again. And smile—for the fairies look upon you both."

With his blessing, we stepped through the gates, leaving the village and its

watchful shadows behind. The fog of the High Forest's capital stretched out before us, dense and unknowable.

I was nervous—how could I not be? But mixed with the tension was something else. Excitement. For the first time in what felt like forever, I wasn't bound by the past.

Yae had said it time and again over the last ten hours, and now the words rang truer than ever.

It was time.

Time to leave behind our grief and face the Lich.